

Go As We Are:
The Neighbourhood
and Its
Political Effects

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2025

Abstract

We might think our local identity is secondary to our other geographic identities, like our national identity. Yet, this is not the case. Many voters consider it as important, or more so, than these higher-order identities. This thesis argues that the 'neighbourhood' is one of our foremost geographic identities, that it is a social identity, and that its effects are more widespread than previously understood. Many studies of place-based identity ignore lower-order identities. Those which do not are often not generalisable because they use limited samples or study only one type of identity, such as rurality. Others measure identity using non-survey-based measures, and political science generally focuses only on radical right voting. Over seven chapters, this thesis models neighbourhood identity and its effects on three key areas of political behaviour: participation, affective polarisation, and candidate choice. Firstly, it shows that those factors which influence it are those which most affect how we form social relationships on the neighbourhood level: social homogeneity, physical distance and time. It finds that it predicts some forms of participation, though mostly low-cost behaviours, such as voting. It shows that, while evidence for the effect of geographic sorting on polarisation is mixed, this is because it is, in part, jointly moderated by voters' place-based identity and contact with their in-group. Finally, while many studies have suggested that voters choose candidates who display descriptive localism because of their own place-based identity, this work, for the first time, demonstrates causally that they do. To do this, it innovatively primes place-based identity and combines this with a forced-choice conjoint. This thesis brings together diverse data, including novel surveys, panel studies and micro-level voting figures, modelling on small geographic units, to provide more credible causal evidence. It raises important questions about how we understand place-based identity, the units and the data we use, and the political effects we study.

Chapter 1

Place and identity

The ache for home lives in all of us, the safe place where we can go as we are and not be questioned. It impels mighty ambitions and dangerous capers. We amass great fortunes at the cost of our souls, or risk our lives in drug dens from London's Soho, to San Francisco's Haight-Ashbury. We shout in Baptist churches, wear yarmulkes and wigs and argue even the tiniest points in the Torah, or worship the sun and refuse to kill cows for the starving. Hoping that by doing these things, home will find us acceptable or failing that, that we will forget our awful yearning for it.

Maya Angelou ¹

In the long summer of 2021, I moved into a housing community based in an old warehouse district in North London. It was the kind of place with its own oat milk café, and where you only had to walk 100 metres to find brunch. The area, a former garment factory, had also been a squat, but was now home to graphic designers, musicians, artists and, ever more so, white-collar workers. Many friends from university had moved in. It was a place where you could easily have fun, which was unworried

¹ *All God's Children Need Traveling Shoes*, p. 196

by the world. It was a place where people held regular chemically assisted parties; it was also the base from which the climate protest group Extinction Rebellion launched its assaults on the industrial world, and was unsurprisingly therefore raided monthly by the police.

This was the summer before I began my PhD, and I moved there looking for freedom after lockdown. I expected that everyone else, like I, would really just be passing through; that I would find mostly independence and rootlessness. But I did not find it. Instead, I found a deep and vibrant community, one that cared greatly about the place they lived, wanted to see others welcomed into it. They organised community events and meetings, watched films together, ran a bar, a performance space, made dinner for neighbours. You could walk down the street and run into half a dozen people you knew. Many people had lived there 10 or 20 years, but many had also, like me, just moved, and, whether they wanted to stay for 10 years or 10 months, dedicated themselves to it just as much. Attachment to somewhere in this way felt slightly alien to me. I was 23 and had just left university after all, and I had moved house metronomically every few years throughout my childhood. But it was also something which belied the impression we have of places like this. It runs against our stereotype of the rootless, atomised city. Clearly, how we feel about place, how we attach meaning to it, has more to it than a simplistic binary definition between places

which look like this and those which are perhaps more conventional, between urban and rural, or young and old. And, I thought, if such a strong attachment existed here, in the most liberal corner of the most unattached, itinerant city in Europe, then how widespread could it be?

And so it is partly from this that I began this work. I knew that it had to begin with the knowledge that the way in which we perceive and study place, and place-based identity on a local level, is often constrained. If we want to understand this identity, we first have to understand that where we live is an indispensable part of how we define ourselves. It contours our home and working lives; it defines our position in society, our health, with whom we spend our time and whom we date. It is something into which our sense of self and outlook upon the world so often are tightly bound. It is also something intimately connected to the many other identities we hold: to our class, our religion, our age, our race. Place functions both as a social category itself and a marker signalling group membership. Among the first questions we will be asked in any social setting is simply 'where are you from?' Where we live is not just a collection of people who consider themselves members of that group, but a complex, cross-cutting assembly of identities. While it is a piece of our identity, it also helps to define all of our other identities. Place is a useful shorthand for so many other social

categories, strata and life stages, which we use to judge ourselves and with which we judge others.

Perhaps this all seems strange. It certainly may seem strange if the impression you have of contemporary society is one that is more cosmopolitan, ever more interconnected with ever more places. We often imagine ourselves, and our politics, as moving above these atavistic influences: the pull of fundamental social categories, of communal identity, of small social networks (Beck 2006; Dalton 2008; Inglehart and Welzel 2014). As Claude Fischer remarked in his study of personal networks in 1970s Californian neighbourhoods, ‘few ideas saturate Western thought as does the conviction that modern life has destroyed “community” ’ (1982, p. 1). You may know how strong place-based identities can be. But many who read this—as urban professionals and intellectuals who may have moved great distances to study or for work—are probably less aware of how much place defines our lives. Most people have a very strong connection to where they live: geographic rootedness is overwhelmingly the norm, even in Western democracies. Only a third of Americans own a valid passport (Yougov 2021); nearly two-thirds live in the state in which they were born (U.S. Census Bureau 2019). In Europe, though the Schengen Area has existed for three decades, 190 million

people—37 per cent of the European Union—have never been abroad.² Nearly 60 per cent of people born in Britain live within 20 miles of where they lived when they were 14.³ Almost a quarter live within two miles.

This question of ‘place-based’ identity has been the subject of significant study in political science, including from Kathy Cramer (2012; 2016), Ryan Enos (2017), Jonathan Rodden (2019) and Jennifer Fitzgerald (2018), among many others. These authors have approached this in different ways, be it rural resentment, the way physical space structures social space, or how we might mistrust outsiders. Some of these studies have also attempted from this to sketch a distinction between a class of people who truly understand place-based identity—older, more rural—and those who do not, memorably summarised by David Goodhart as the ‘anywheres’ and the ‘somewheres’ (Goodhart 2017). All this is highly salient, too. As I write this in 2025, Western democracies are still experiencing political upheavals—the reshaping of party systems, increasing polarisation and the decline of traditional voting models—which can be partly attributed to an assertion of this identity. Many academic studies have linked this identity to radical right voting (Bolet 2021; Cramer 2016; Fitzgerald 2018; Lyons and

² Data taken from Eurobarometer 414, for 2014 (Data Europa EU 2014).

³ Data taken from the UK Household Longitudinal Study (ISER et al. 2023).

Utych 2021; Munis 2022), as well as to how we choose 'local' candidates (Arzheimer and Evans 2014; Munis 2021; Schulte-Cloos and Bauer 2021).

But this work leaves much to be desired. Most of all, it lacks external validity. Many studies of place-based identity are qualitative. Many quantitative studies look only at a specific type of identity, such as municipal or rural identity. In both instances, they make it difficult to apply to other cases. If we understand place-based identity only in relation to a small sample of people or only in one place, such as rural areas, for instance, then we are missing something fundamental. In focusing, as many studies do, only at the macro-level, such as regions, cities or towns, we are ignoring variation on smaller units, of our immediate social environment, like the 'neighbourhood'. I argue that the dynamics which shape identity and its effects are likely very different here and therefore worthy of a separate study. There are other problems, too. In trying to measure it, many quantitative studies use awkward proxies—distance from birthplace, for instance, or variation in regional dialects or residency, for example—which do not really get at what this identity, this emotional attachment to place, really is, and preclude a more fine-tuned measure which may capture it more accurately. Finally, the focus in research on the radical right—an identity defined by hostility towards out-groups—is misplaced, because it is often not clear who the geographic out-group

actually is, and because it assumes a hostility towards out-groups which is not always present in social identities, particularly ones based on place.

These are the central issues that I set out to address. I will try to convince you that, in studying this identity, we should be focusing on our immediate social environment—the people and groups with whom we live—first and foremost, and therefore defining it primarily as a social identity, rather than an attachment to the physical space, or to culture or history, for instance. To do this, I collect and model high-quality data from several sources: panel studies, micro-level census and electoral data, large cross-national surveys, a novel observational survey, national-level surveys, and a survey experiment. Where I can, I model on extremely small units: neighbourhoods of only a few thousand people. I measure people's attachment to their neighbourhood directly using survey questions, and I look at different political effects: political participation, affective partisan polarisation, and attitudes towards political candidates.

It is important to say what this thesis is not, too. It is not an exploration of a 'local identity' or 'character' in the sense that I am exploring what it means to be a New Yorker or a Londoner or someone from a specific named place. Instead, I am exploring what it means to be someone who feels attached to their neighbourhood, as they might feel attached to any neighbourhood in which they live, for whom their neighbourhood identity is part of their self-identity, just as if they also feel belonging to

other social categories. Of course, one's identity as a New Yorker, for instance, may be primarily defined in this way, in terms of the social groups there. Still, I am exploring what it means to be attached to neighbourhood mostly shorn of specific cultural connotations and history, and without dominant lenses, like the media, framing our perspective. Instead, I develop a theory of granular place-based identity which is far more generalisable, far more applicable to comparable cases. These other approaches are interesting and necessary, but sacrifice external validity for specificity. Finally, this is also not a study of political 'localism' in the sense that I am specifically studying municipal politics, for instance.

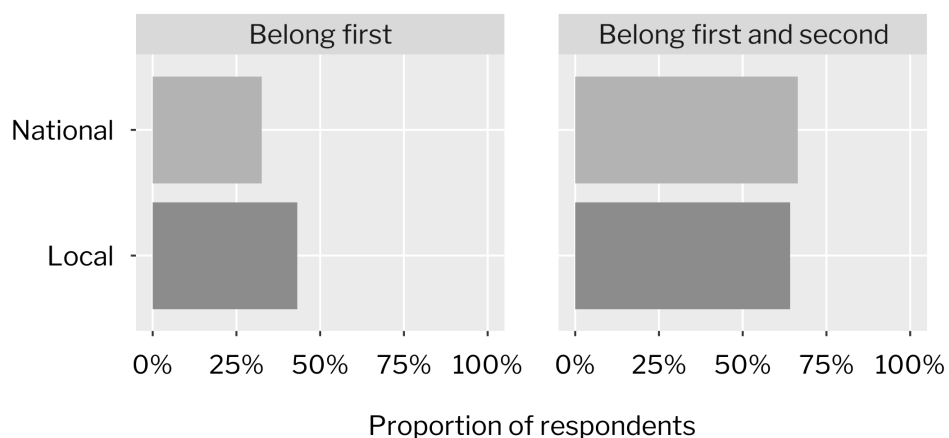


Figure 1.1: How people rank attachment to country and 'locality' in Europe (European Values Study)

1.1 The importance of place

It is good to start by considering what we mean when we talk about place. Different geographies naturally hold different meanings to people. We attach very different meaning to the city as to the neighbourhood, or to the country. We might assume that the nation is always our primary place-based identity, or at least that it is far more important than our other geographic identities. We would be wrong to do so. When asking Europeans to rank their attachment to 'locality', or country, among several options which include regional, European, and global identities, over 10 per cent more choose their locality over their country in first place (Figure 1.1). Even when adding in second preferences, the two identities are roughly equal, and almost two-thirds of people have a strong local attachment. It is also, in Europe at least, not a constrained phenomenon; it is fairly uniformly spread across the continent (Figure A1.1 in Appendix I). It is also a consistent identity across time. As I said earlier, we might imagine that we are increasingly connected across space, less rooted, less attached to where we live than 20 or even 10 years ago. This is not the case. As Figure 1.2 shows, attachment to locality across many Western democracies is remarkably consistent over the last 40 years. And, though attachment is slightly lower among younger people, the difference is tiny. The story is the same for income. Though higher earners are, on average, less

attached than those who earn less, the gap is negligible. It is also remarkably stable when we measure this by strength of identity (Figure A1.2).

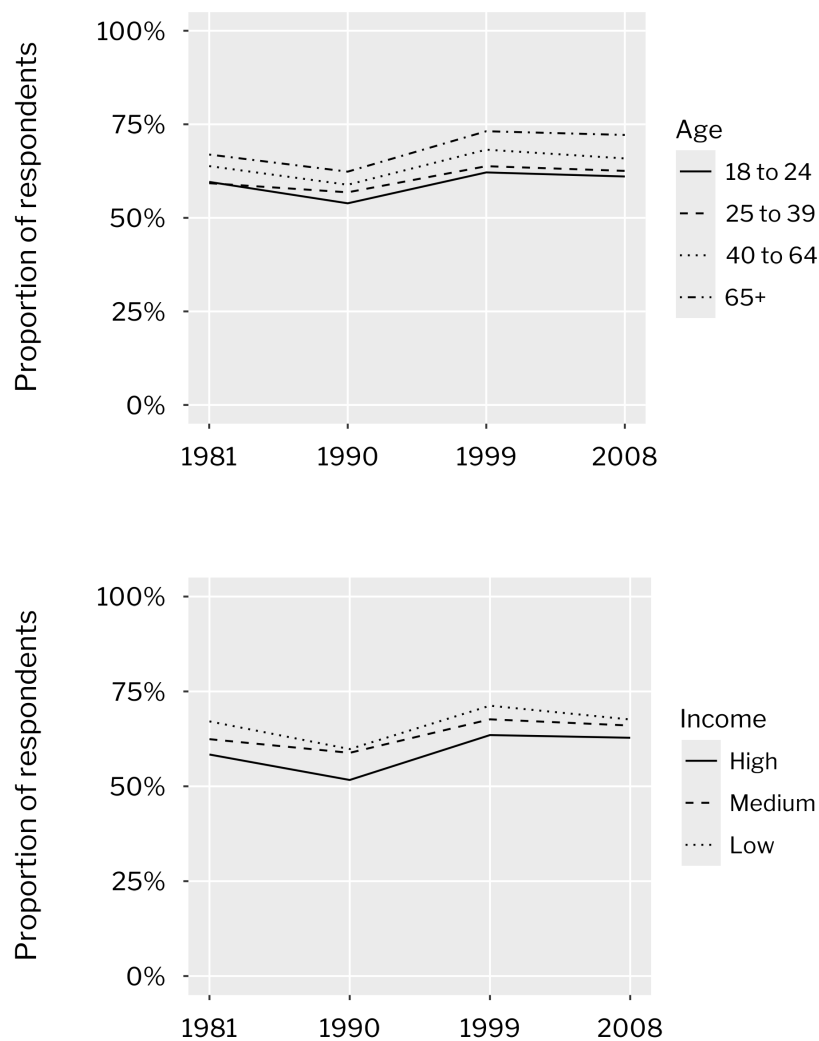


Figure 1.2: Attachment to locality across Europe over time by age and income (EVS). Income based on household income: categories vary by country, so that each contains approximately one-third of the country's sample

I make an argument throughout this work that place-based identity on the neighbourhood level is primarily a social identity, and that it is as important as those other social identities—class, race and gender, for instance—which we take to be pre-eminent in politics (Evans and Tilley 2017; Huddy and Feldman 2009; Paxton et al. 2007). Indeed, despite the weight of research in political science falling on the effects of these other identities, more people see their local identity as important to their sense of political self than almost any other social identity: above race, class and religion, and behind only gender (Table 1.1). Place also has the potential to be shaped by some of the same factors as these other identities. And this sense of place as social identity is arguably intuitively how we see the world. For those people living in the old warehouses in London, their emotional attachment to where they lived, and the identity this formed, were defined not just by the physical place itself but by the people who live there. Think of where you live, too. A large part of your impression of a place is probably made up of the people who live in it. Political behaviour and our engagement in politics are inherently social actions. They are therefore strongly determined by how we relate to social groups and our role within them. This does not mean that such an identity is without connotation, however, but it is later, I suggest, that we might come to assign values, culture or tradition. In doing this, I argue that we should be thinking in terms of where we live now, rather than how we identify with another place, perhaps

Table 1.1: Which social groups people see themselves as belonging to

Gender	62%
Area	55%
Ethnicity	52%
Class	52%
Share views/vote like me	52%
Education	51%
Political party	34%
Religion	29%

Asking ‘in politics... do you think of yourself as part of’ each group. From a nationally-representative survey of adults in Great Britain conducted in December 2020 (Bunting et al. 2025). N = 817

our birthplace if we have moved, for instance. These other geographic identities are important, but they are shaped and influence the world differently from those places where we live and where we interact with people daily.

1.1.1 Social identity

Scholars have long been interested in the question of how geography structures human behaviour. Attachment to place has been a focus of modern empirical study since at least Ferdinand Tönnies in the 19th century (Tönnies 1988[1887]), and Louis Wirth and George Herbert Mead five decades later (1938 and 1934). The study of place is

broad and multidisciplinary; geographic identity has long been the concern of sociology and environmental psychology in particular. Political science has also focused on this study of place, going back to V.O. Key's seminal midcentury work on neighbour voting patterns in the Southern United States (Key 1949). Over the last seven decades, many scholars have studied how geography influences political behaviour, how space shapes human interaction and identity (Butler and Stokes 1971; Cox 1969; Dahl and Tufte 1973). But while political science has long understood group identity to be a strong motivator of political behaviour—we know much about how our attachment to social groups, such as class or race, influences politics, for instance (Conover 1984; Huddy 2013; Huddy et al. 2015; Miller et al. 1981)—we know far less about the role of affective bonds with place. While this is changing—see Borwein and Lucas (2021), Bühlmann (2012), Fitzgerald (2018), B. Kal Munis (2021), or Cara Wong (2010) for instance—it is still emergent, and limited.

Most ways of defining social identity involve establishing psychological links between our personal identity and our group identities or social strata. Throughout this thesis, I primarily rely on social identity theory, first developed by Henry Tajfel, John Turner and their colleagues in the 1970s and 1980s (Hogg and Abrams 1988; Tajfel 1978; Tajfel and Turner 1979; Turner 1981). Social identity theory is helpful for several reasons. Firstly, its conclusions have been widely reproduced, and therefore there

is a large body of literature to work from. Secondly, it speaks to an understanding of social identity which emphasises the importance of group-based affiliations and the psychological processes which shape group identification. Thirdly, its observation that group categorisation can happen without conflict or competing goals is essential here. As I show throughout this thesis, this is an identity that does not necessarily come with negative affect towards an out-group.

This latter argument is important because it means that our assumption that place-based identity primarily drives voting for the radical right, a behaviour which is usually driven by dislike of outsiders, be they political elites, migrants, or city-dwellers, is misplaced. But it is misplaced for another reason too: that if we are considering lower-order identities like the neighbourhood, then it is not really clear who the out-group is. Calling the migrant or the political elite the out-group makes sense when you define place-based identity as a category. Many studies equate place-based identity with rural identity, for instance, and therefore creating this amorphous 'other' makes sense; see Cramer (2016) and Fitzgerald (2018). But it does not make sense for the neighbourhood and, even when we do, we are confusing a specific geographic out-group with one based on values. I find direct evidence for this conclusion too, in Chapter 5, where neighbourhood attachment has no ability to predict negative attitudes towards the out-group.

1.1.2 Why the neighbourhood?

Why focus on the neighbourhood in all this, though? Throughout this work, I centre on this term or, to a lesser extent where this is not possible, the 'local area' and similar, as the primary unit of analysis. There are several reasons for this. Firstly, as we will see in Chapter 2, the specific idea of the 'neighbourhood' captures for many people one's social environment. The neighbourhood is somewhere we live out much of our free time; in most people's conception probably large enough to contain within it amenities for that time: places to shop, to socialise, see friends and neighbours, to exercise and to relax. At the same time, it is small enough for us to have some realistic sense of its inhabitants. If our behaviour is shaped by our attitudes towards the groups which make up an area, then the places where we have greater knowledge of, and greater interaction with others, are likely the places where we will find these dynamics to be strongest, or at least significantly different. Secondly, 'neighbourhood' is a term most people are familiar with and may use in their everyday lives. It is a relatively specific unit, with clear boundaries, one which allows us to imagine specific and concrete features: streets, blocks, roads, parks. Partly, we also do not want to enforce too rigid a definition on people, and allow for some difference in interpretation of what

'neighbourhood' means so that, when people are asked, they can apply their own. Defining something so granularly also means any spillover effects are less concerning.

I use the term 'neighbourhood attachment' throughout this work because I want to emphasise this focus.⁴ But I also choose this name because I want to emphasise that lower-order identities such as this are different. While attachment to neighbourhood is like attachment to country, and other higher-order identities, in that they are both place-based identities and social identities, there is more which separates them than connects them. Nations are groups of people bound primarily by culture, language and history; people who will never know each other. They are 'imagined' in Benedict Anderson's famous phrase (Anderson 1983). Our immediate social environment is, of course, also partly imagined. We are unlikely to be familiar with, let alone even recognise, all our neighbours. The neighbourhood is therefore like other higher-order identities: somewhere social groups operate, of which we have some idea but which we do not know in its entirety. However, unlike most of these other identities, we do at least have some chance of knowing them, perhaps a fairly good chance, and we are also able to have an idea of its physical form and position in space. We may also have a good sense of the types of groups that live there. At the same time, it is not

⁴ A more general term is commonly 'place-based social identity' (Cramer 2012; Cramer 2016; Schulte-Cloos and Bauer 2021; Ziblatt et al. 2020).

a connection to a whole category or group of people like other social identities, other than that which is conveyed by residence. It is therefore unique, both as a place-based identity, and a social identity.

‘Neighbourhood’ or related framing has been used in similar research (Chan and Kawalerowicz 2021; Fitzgerald 2018; Ward et al. 2025). This approach is, however, unusual. Most previous work has focused on a named area—a city, district or region perhaps—or a specific urban form—your ‘town’, ‘village’ or ‘municipality’. In focusing on such granular, unnamed units here, we are gaining external validity: it allows me to extrapolate to any such similar units in other cases. It also allows me to avoid instances where we may be attached to places we do not live. With larger, more recognisable units or categories of units—‘rural areas’ for instance, or a famous city—there is some evidence that those not living there can feel belonging towards it, as well as confusion regarding whether the place you live constitutes part of that category (Trujillo 2022a; Trujillo 2022b). Instead, with the neighbourhood, residency is essential. There is also evidence that this is how people actually think. Taking data from Wave 3 of the British Election Study Internet Panel (Fieldhouse et al. 2019), conducted in 2014, over three-quarters of voters see the ‘neighbourhood’ as the object which represents their local community, far above any of the, typically more concrete, options, such as local stores, common contacts, and friends (Table 1.2). People also have a rough idea

of what this means in terms of their neighbours. Taken from that same survey, the median number of people respondents claim to know by name in their local area is 25, although many claim to know much more (Figure A1.3).

Table 1.2: What people think of as their local community

Your neighbourhood	75%
Your grocery store, library, post office, church, or other places you visit on a regular basis	47%
People you see on a regular basis	38%
Family and friends	33%
People like you	20%
Your workplace or school	18%
People or places you think about when you may vote in an election	16%
What you see in newspapers, on television, or on the internet	7%

Proportion of respondents answering. Respondents choose as many answers as they wish (British Election Study IP, wave 3, 2014). N = 28,574

But this must have a strong grounding in theory. Chapter 2 presents my theoretical framework. I draw from a literature which includes influences from sociology, social and environmental psychology, as well as political science. It is here that I attempt to establish attachment to neighbourhood as an identity distinct from other important social and geographic identities like our national identity, race or class. In this chapter, I also propose a simple measurement approach and question phrasing to measure this

identity, based on the concept of 'belonging' to a place, and justify in greater depth a focus on the 'neighbourhood'. What causes us to develop this identity in the first place, though? Chapter 3, the first empirical chapter, answers this, modelling small neighbourhoods, and studying neighbourhood attachment directly using measures from nationally-representative surveys: those areas where we are often methodologically let down by the literature. Combining census data with the European Values Study and UK Household Longitudinal Study (UKHLS), a large, high-quality British panel study, it examines what predicts attachment using mixed-effects and dynamic panel models. Along with fixed effects models, I use a similar modelling strategy across all of the observational chapters. I focus on social 'homogeneity'—whether our neighbourhood looks like us socially—and those factors which affect our ability to develop strong social relations: time and distance. It is in this chapter that we find out what the average voter who espouses neighbourhood attachment looks like. They have large, local family networks, have not moved far or often in their lives, and generally live in neighbourhoods which look like them racially and socio-economically. All this is not constrained to rural areas, however; they are about as likely to live in cities as in rural areas, though slightly more inclined towards the latter.

1.1.3 Political effects

Many political studies of place-based identity are limited in looking only at voting for the radical right. I examine a broader range of effects, studying three areas and focusing on behaviour that is socially determined: political participation, affective partisan polarisation, and candidate preferences. Chapter 4 first considers that most fundamental aspect of political behaviour: whether we engage in politics at all, and how we do so when we do. I use three waves of the UKHLS, as well as the European Social Survey, to test several activities, such as voting, protesting and campaigning. To this, I match micro-level census data and a collated dataset of ward-level election results in Britain going back two decades. I use this to explore variation based on political 'homogeneity': whether a respondent's partisan identity matches that of their neighbourhood. What I find is that attachment to neighbourhood consistently means that we participate. This appears to be influenced both by a desire to channel resources to our area and to defend our social group, motivated in part by threat, prevalent primarily in neighbourhoods where we are surrounded by our political enemies. This is limited mostly to low-cost activities, however. While we may vote more, we are not motivated to do anything as involved as protesting or campaigning.

How we think about our political identity as a social identity is also important, and so Chapter 5 turns to affective polarisation: polarisation based on social groups. Many voters increasingly live in neighbourhoods which vote similarly to them. This increasing homogeneity is often suggested as a key influence on growing political polarisation in Western democracies (Tilley and Hobolt 2024). The evidence for the effect of neighbourhood partisan homogeneity on affective polarisation in the literature is inconsistent, however, and often nonexistent (Martin and Webster 2020; Tilley and Hobolt 2024). In this chapter, I argue that this is because we are not considering our affective attachment to neighbourhood, and that this, in fact, moderates the impact of political echo chambers on polarisation. To show this, I use a nationally-representative survey from Britain, combined with bespoke neighbourhood-level estimates of vote intention, and real-world microdata on social relations, as well as UKHLS panel data. I find that attachment to neighbourhood does appear to moderate this effect, and a relationship that had previously been null becomes positive. This relationship is stronger in the presence of a third factor: when we are likely to interact more with our local in-group, in neighbourhoods which are relatively poorly socially integrated into adjoining ones.

But, as fundamental in representative democracy as whether we participate is who represents us. Chapter 6 looks at voters' preferences towards these candidates.

Previous experimental studies of preferences for descriptive localism in candidates have omitted to evaluate the effect of a decisive factor: voters' own place-based identity. Many more studies hint at this effect, but do not test it experimentally. Here, I do this, using a unique experimental design to induce participants' place-based identity and evaluate its effects on candidate choice. I show both that it is possible to manipulate this identity and that doing so clearly induces us to choose the local candidate. I also address a second shortcoming in the experimental literature: the conflating of some candidate localism cues, such as birthplace and residency. Here, I show that disentangling these cues reveals significant heterogeneity, both across the profiles in general and in what primed voters select.

1.2 Approach

To test all this, I use a wide range of data: high-quality household panel data, large cross-national surveys, novel national-level surveys, micro-level census and voting data, and a survey experiment. My data covers Britain, Europe and the United States, and therefore covers many democracies in which the issues I look at—identity, candidate choice, political participation and turnout, and polarisation—are salient and topical.

The survey which I use most, the UK Household Longitudinal Study (UKHLS, also known as *Understanding Society*), is relatively underused in political science. Different panels I use cover over a decade, employing detailed indicators regarding social networks, geographic mobility, neighbours and neighbourhood, and allows me to render many of these relationships across time. I also use a restricted version of the data which gives me participants' real addresses, using which I can model highly granular neighbourhoods. To these surveys, I match real-world data. This includes high-quality census data; Chapters 4 and 5 similarly also use ward-level data on voting in local elections in Britain. I employ all this to construct specific measures of neighbourhood political and social context. Chapter 5 also utilises a unique dataset of voters' Facebook friendships to model the social connectedness of areas. In most cases, I model neighbourhoods consistently across much of my data, using very small units of only a few thousand residents. There is experimental evidence too: the mixed vignette and conjoint design, which I use to test the effect of neighbourhood attachment in Chapter 6.

Throughout this thesis, I aim to make three key points: why we should care about this identity, how we should define it, and how it impacts political behaviour. In Chapter 2, I argue that it is the neighbourhood, more than any other unit, that we should talk about when talking about place-based identity. In Chapter 3, it is the

'who': who are the voters who evince attachment, and what causes them to be so?

The next three chapters look at the 'how': how can we observe the effect of this identity on political behaviour? Chapter 4 looks at political participation, Chapter 5 at affective polarisation, and Chapter 6 at political candidates. Each chapter takes a slightly different approach to its question, though they share data.

Place is an essential piece of our identity, and our relationship with it is one of the defining anchors of many of our lives. At the same time, we have been thinking of it, in political science, in too constrained a way, and have, as well, not considered the full range of its potential political effects. Most of all, we have often not, in quantitative studies, considered the neighbourhood, considered lower-order identities. We have not thought in the right way in political science about how we might define it, how seeing it as a social identity changes how we understand it and how this might therefore structure political behaviour differently. Hopefully, by the end of this work, you will be persuaded of its importance. Hopefully, you will also be convinced of its effects on our politics. That it is, fundamentally, impossible to ignore.

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Appendix I



Figure A1.1: Proportion of respondents expressing belonging to 'locality' in Europe, all countries available (EVS)

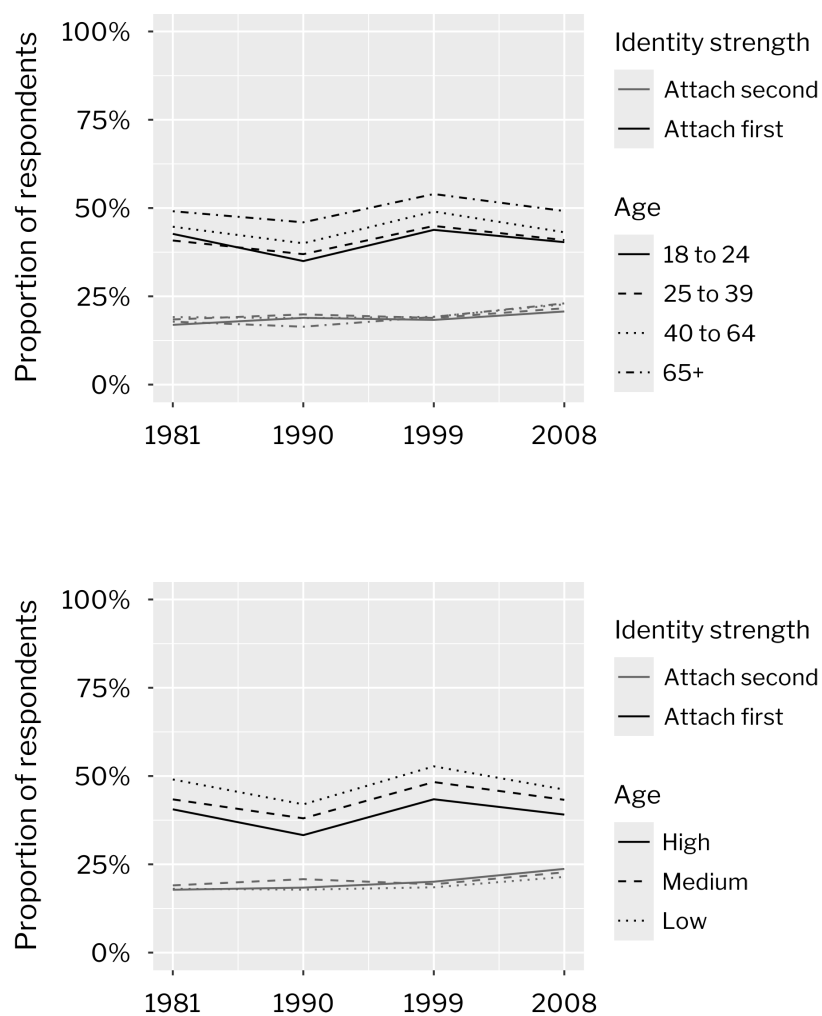


Figure A1.2: Strength of attachment to locality across Europe over time by age and income (EVS). Income based on household income: categories vary by country, so that each contains approximately one-third of the country's sample

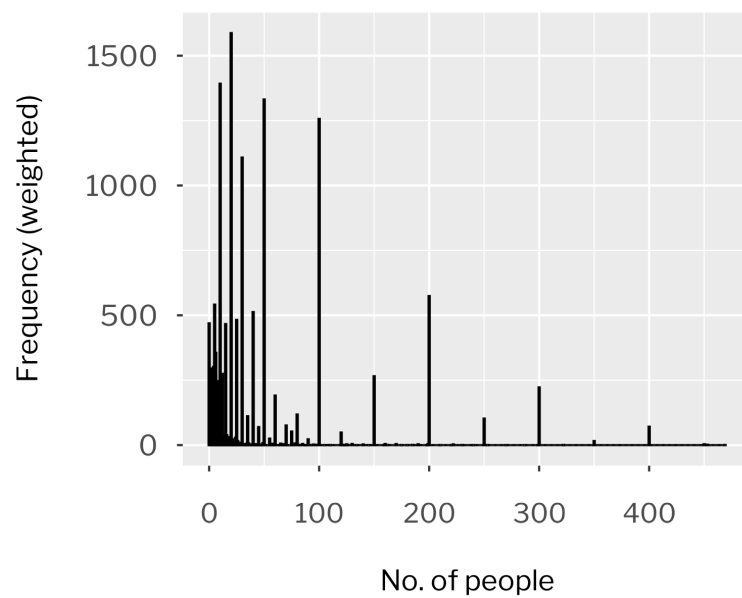


Figure A1.3: How many people voters claim they can name in their 'local area' (British Election Study IP, wave 3). Outliers above 500 removed

A1.1 BES questions (Wave 3 Internet Panel)

Perceptions of local community

We'd like you to picture in your mind what you think of as your local community. This can be as large or small an area as you like, and you can imagine one or multiple areas that make up your local community.

The next questions refer to this local community. What were you thinking about as you were imagining your local community? Please tick all that apply.

- ☐ Family and friends
- ☐ People you see on a regular basis
- ☐ Your neighbourhood
- ☐ Your workplace or school
- ☐ Your grocery store, library, post office, church, or other places you visit on a regular basis
- ☐ People like you
- ☐ People or places you think about when you may vote in an election
- ☐ What you see in newspapers, on television, or on the internet

Size of local community

Roughly how many people would you say you know by name in your local community? Please enter the number of people (using numbers not words) in the box. It does not have to be exact.

A1.2 TrustGov questions

In politics, to what extent, if at all, do you think of yourself as part of each of the following groups?

- Share views/vote like me
- Class
- Ethnicity
- Gender
- Area
- Education
- Political party
- Religion

Responses to each given on a five-item Likert scale.